

Temple Bar

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THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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Temple Bar in Fleet Street before 1878



Languishing in Hertfordshire - 2000



Back in the City 2006

When the Roman invaders of Britain took up residence in Londinium (circa 50 BC), they needed to build a substantial wall to enclose the City and protect its citizens from the locals. This wall enclosing the Square Mile has largely disappeared over centuries. Small sections remain, uncovered by excavations during development.

The existence of a protective wall required access points. There were a number of these, but the principal ceremonial route was the one from Westminster to the City. The first records of a gate to control access at this point date from 1293 – it may have been no more than a chain draped between two posts. Further gates followed; the gate in existence in 1666 escaped the Great Fire but was replaced under the Commission set up by King Charles II to designs by Sir Christopher Wren. The gate was built between 1669 and 1672 by Thomas Knight, the City Mason, and Joshua Marshall, Master of the Masons' Company. The four niches at the upper level contained statues of Anne of Denmark (wife of King James I), James I, Charles I, and Charles II. The last known use of the Upper Chamber in the original position at the western end of Fleet Street was the storage of records for Child and Co Bank.

In 1878, the Corporation, in order to widen Fleet Street, dismantled the structure (whose arches had dropped and were held up by timbers) piece by piece and stored the 2,700 stones in South London. The idea of its reuse as the formal point of entry to their home at Theobalds Park in Hertfordshire came from the wife of former Lord Mayor Sir Henry Meux, who was, according to a contemporary

account, 'a banjo-playing barmaid/actress' who had married into the family of wealthy London brewers. Following her husband's death Lady Meux became something of a celebrity hostess and fashion icon. When rebuilt in 1889, 'a magnificent garden party was held in celebration and special trains brought in large numbers of visitors who stood in awe of this historic relic'. While under the ownership of Lady Meux, her guests were regularly entertained in the upper chamber of Temple Bar, decorated with 'Spy' cartoons from Vanity Fair, and Lady Meux dined there with Edward VII, the Prince of Wales and Winston Churchill.

Sadly, the construction of the M25 rendered access via Temple Bar impossible and the monument decayed until 2003, though the original Temple Bar Trustees (under former Lord Mayor Sir Hugh Wontner) had acquired it in 1984 for £1 and planned its return to the City of London. Various sites were considered and the current location at the entrance to the new Paternoster Square development was selected. The works on dismantling the structure and its re-erection commenced in 2004, with the monument being officially opened by Lord Mayor Sir Robert Finch in November 2004. Those in charge of the dismantling had reason to regret the use of an inappropriate mortar in the 1889 rebuild and the numerous subsequent running repairs to the structure.

After much discussion it was agreed that the chamber above the gates should be leased to the Worshipful Company of Chartered Architects, who would use it and adjacent space in Paternoster Lodge (through which access is gained) as their City headquarters and a base for educational outreach under the new Temple Bar Trust, which seeks to promote architecture to a wider public.